What's the main differences in tone and theming between Cursebourne and W/CoD?



Mr.Jaxus
Member

Join Date: Nov 2013
Posts: 379

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What's the main differences in tone and theming between Cursebourne and W/CoD?

#1

07-03-2026, 06:29 PM

So as the title says, what's the thematic and tone differences between Curseborne and World/Chronicles of Darkness?

To summarise my experience with WoD and CoD; I'm not super invested in them but I know a lot of people who are and I have flicked through the Tvtropes pafe to try and better understand it, I've also played in a Werewolf the Forsaken campaign that had several different splat (mummy, vampire, changling and **a** mage(as a treat)). I know roughly what each splat's deal is and the general theme differences between WoD and CoD (WoD is darker and more focused on meta-plot, CoD is (relatively) lighter and less world defining meta plots). As a general rule I'm more of an Exalted fan than WoD/CoD.

The main thing I'm aware of in Curseborne is there is a lot more inter-splat interaction but that's most of my knowledge on the game

My homebrew blog

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07-03-2026, 09:42 PM #2



monteparnas
Member

Join Date: Apr 2015
Posts: 6710

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I'm still getting into it, but one main difference is that the focus is more on the idea of being a/the buffer against the Outside, a host of hostile other dimensions.

Curses are normal in the setting, so there is a certain sense of naturalism to the supernatural as in no matter how fucked up your situation is, at the end of the day you're still pretty much a legit part of this world.

Splat politics still exist but are downplayed, with local circumstances being more important and your investment in splat politics being a personal choice.

Overall it's less focus on splat society and more on what you chose to take from your splat, and the group will deal with liminalities, out of control anomalies and nihilistic assholes.

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Heavy Arms
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Join Date: Nov 2013
Posts: 12634

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07-04-2026, 02:28 AM #3

In terms of tone... I think Curseborne does a lot to capture the current zeitgeist instead of trying to capture/update the Gothic-Punk concepts of the WoD. It's very much the more modern approach to cosmic horror that well... doesn't really get "cosmic" in the way the phrase can sound. It focuses on the twisting of the familiar into something unsettling to merge the uncaring nature of the Mythos entities with the intimacy of the other games' personal horror.

In the WoD and CofD, urban legends and now creepypastas are flavor to spice up a world of extensively detailed supernatural groups. Curseborne is a setting where such horrors are more the norm of what's going on. If you want to lift the basics of a mascot horror video game (eg: FNAF and such)... you can basically just slot that in. You don't have to worry about how it fits into the metaphysics and themes of the different game lines of the *oD stuff. To reference a bunch of horror movie gems... it's a game where a preserved hand that lets you talk to ghosts floats around at parties, wishing your crush would love you will go extremely wrong, and clipping into a room that shouldn't exist are all baked into what the game is aiming for. The big difference is the PCs are default capable of dealing with such intrusions into normalcy instead of being normal people who are lucky if they can run away and survive.

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ArcaneArts
Member

07-04-2026, 09:12 AM #4

Thematically and tonally, the game's "hopepunk"* direction has to be acknowledged.

The World of Darkness is drenched in it's millenial apocalypticism, and it's systems and political structures are all so hopelessly rotted and corrupted that there's no real stopping the machine, only ensuring that the fuckers who made things this bad get to ride out the end of the world in the same way the rest of everyone do. It's more classical punk fueled by anger inflicted by a fatalistic



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outlook on the issues of the day, tempered with the gothic appreciation of rot and decay that can find meaning and beauty in otherwise terrible times. Cosmic horror elements are rendered as an oncoming background that can make all the petty squabbles of the political, the deliberate, the actions of actors still thinking something can be made or done either all the more meaningful or pointless.

Chronicles of Darkness goes more gothic than punk and dives more into mystery as a genre, with what can broadly be called a "learning to live in dark times" approach to everything. The world is full of malign powers and crisscrossing purposes, intentions, patterns, signals, and afflictions, a tapestry made from spools too numerous to really ever unravel all of it...and yet, despite that, the world keeps on turning, people continue to live, and even the monsters who deal with more of the brunt force of the supernatural are able to make a home and a peace with the way of things, and the unveiling of truths, both the personal and impersonal, can often be pretty rewarding, even if at the end of it all, nothing can really be *done* about it-and even if the big picture is what it is, you can make your life, and the lives of those around you, just that much better. For however much all the various forms of horror dance around and toss those who get caught up in it, at the end of the day, the world still turns, and if the stars are secretly teeth, they remain bright all the same.

Curseborne goes back to punk as an ideal, and it goes at it hard....but also strongly believes in a light at the end of the tunnel, rejecting apocalypticism and simply coming to terms and making peace with the world. The world is maligned with curses, but curses come from *somewhere*, it comes from *someone*, and those entities, in theory, can be brought to task, and in so doing the world can be made better. The world is the way it is, not because that's just the way it is, but because of a supernatural equivalent of man-made climate change. It's a game that believes in subverting the tools of the master in the pursuit of destroying their house, and breaking them apart and reshaping them into something that can if it can't on it's own. There's cosmic horror, but the game works to render the impersonal into something personal, getting possibly the most street level of the three-Cthulhu is pretty punchable here.

I don't want to make it sound like there isn't tragedy or angst in CB-recently released to backers novella Peel Back the Bark ends with a pretty strong downer, and at the end of the day, the Accursed call their signature curses Damnations for a reason-but by and large Curseborne is interested in taking those feelings and turning it into action. It's a very cinematic action-y type of horror game, appropriate given the Storypath Ultra engine.

Later this year, we're going to be getting Curseborne Covenant, which both explores higher powered characters and conspiracies with a larger look on the world, what's going on with it, and what can be done with it, and it'll be interesting to see how much of the hopepunk attitude continues into that sphere. For now though, probably the biggest difference about CB against it's predecessors is that, while it does dig into monstrosity and horror, it doesn't really dwell on the burden of living with it, and instead gets keen on how you can bend the affliction to your advantage, and possibly the benefit of others.

*we really need a better word than hopepunk, though I acknowledge "heroic" also misses the point.

Kelly R.S. Steele, Freelance Writer(Feel free to call me Kelly, Arcane, or Arc)
The world is not beautiful, therefore it is.-Keiichi Sigsawa, Kino's Journey
Feminine pronouns, please.

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Posts: 12634

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07-04-2026, 01:45 PM #5

I think part of the problem is the word/suffix of "punk" has kinda lost a distinct meaning and thus doesn't explain as much as it used to. Any given person is going to hear it as a mixture of a various musical aesthetics, an antiestablishment inclination, and designation of literary subgenres. Hopepunk kinda leaning hard into the third while CB wants to lean into the second.

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monteparnas
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07-04-2026, 06:25 PM #6

> *Originally posted by **ArcaneArts***
> **we really need a better word than hopepunk, though I acknowledge "heroic" also misses the point.*

I think the word you're seeking here is just Punk.

WoD wasn't as apocalyptic, but the Punk message frequently got lost in the setting expansion.

Golconda was achievable and good, the PCs had a real shot at changing Sept politics and fight the Wyrm more efficiently, Ascension was perfectly achievable and the war winnable.

The books of course assumed things were still bad, the constant character-narrator meant the narrator wouldn't say to your face that the game could end well. That was the Gothic part getting through, and players thoroughly embraced the darkness rather than the message, but WoD had a pretty similar core where the apparently insurmountable problems were there actually for your group to solve.

And this is a lot of what Punk is at its core, past the fatalist attitude of anger-filled revolt. It's not bowing to the system, instead knowing if you can't defeat the system playing by its rules, you'll just make do with a metal bat.

Which doesn't have to be too literal, plenty Punks weren't violent even if plenty were.

So, yes. I think WoD is Gothic-Punk, CofD is far more just Gothic (I'd say it's also more mystery with Weird Fiction rather than straight horror), and Curseborne is what we can finally just call Punk Horror. Or maybe Punk Pasta.

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JackalopeVegas
Member

Join Date: Nov 2013
Posts: 246

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07-09-2026, 05:02 PM #7

Thematically, it's still Gothicpunk as both games have similar themes of rebellion and finding your path. A slight difference would be how the splats see the Umbra/Outside. In WoD, each splat has their own theory of how it works and how the interact with it. With Curseborne, it's more monolithic as every splat had the same experience with Outsiders like the Fae. On another route, you can totally abuse the Brood system to insert WoD/CoD elements into Curseborne like how the popular Get of Fenris could be a Nordic brood of the Get of Lyka due to cultural differences.

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DarkKing
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Posts: 639

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07-11-2026, 06:06 PM #8

People say that an armed society, is a polite society.

I like to think that the same applies for a haunted society.

If you know that ghosts exist, you're going to feel a lot less inclined to commit violent crimes.

Especially when there's the chance that one or more of your victims might come back as a vengeful Fury.

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Heavy Arms
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Posts: 12634

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07-12-2026, 04:30 AM #9

People say a lot of things that are quotes taken out of context because they sound pithy; as they should when they were originally written by skilled authors. The character that said it thinks that politeness is actually besides the point and the the main benefit of a society that solves most conflicts with duels is that stupid people get killed and stop being a drain on everyone else.

There's no evidence for, and a lot of evidence against, the idea that more weapons = more polite people. The whole point of the novel is that humans aren't wired for that kind of rational self-interest but enough are aware enough to justify hoping to breed a future generation that finally is; which would make the need to carry firearms obsolete by the logic of the setting anyway.

In the real world, most people say they believe in some sort of supernatural

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entities that either can or will judge them for their actions... and serious violence (criminal or not by the standards of the day and place) continues to stick with us. So the idea that adding ghosts in the mix would stop people is questionable. In the end of the day, the majority of people are going to make choices that have predictable negative consequences because humans are like that. Adding in the supernatural being known instead of believed isn't going to change that.

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DarkKing
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Join Date: Dec 2025
Posts: 639

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07-12-2026, 01:13 PM #10

> *Originally posted by **Heavy Arms***
> *People say a lot of things that are quotes taken out of context because they sound pithy; as they should when they were originally written by skilled authors. The character that said it thinks that politeness is actually besides the point and the the main benefit of a society that solves most conflicts with duels is that stupid people get killed and stop being a drain on everyone else.*

Are they wrong, though? Criminal masterminds are few and far between. Most real world criminals are notoriously stupid.

Now I wonder if a ghost is allowed to testify at their murder trial?

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monteparnas
Member

Join Date: Apr 2015
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07-12-2026, 02:24 PM #11

> *Originally posted by **DarkKing***
> *Are they wrong, though?*

Demonstrably, yes.

Most criminals are normal, actually. Stupid criminals get caught in comedic ways that make for funny videos, they don't represent most actual criminals, though.

Stupid people also do other things. Most aren't criminals, and in fact a lot of stupid people are also hard workers that contribute a lot. A lot others are the kind of stupid that thinks everyone else is and don't notice how useless they are. A lot of useless people are smart, too, especially since it takes smarts to be useless and still look like you're helping a lot.

Crime rates are not a mystery. Its one of the few social data people document in some way as soon as they develop the notion of documenting things.

Yes, they get manipulated and have gaps. But we have a notion of criminality and penalities for virtually every community with written records to have ever existed, the sheer volume of data is staggering.

So this is not a supposition, it's an observed fact: access to weapons or belief in ghosts do not reduce criminality, or lack of politeness. No society gets safer

because of guns. Increasing access also don't have a big impact, but is still worse than reducing. And religion, superstition, no belief in supernatural punishment affects it, either.

For the record, the most armed country in the world after the US, and only with overall more permissive gun laws, is Yemen. Neither figure among safest or more polite in the world.

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07-12-2026, 03:00 PM #12

Also, the phrase "criminal masterminds," it tautological with being rare. A mastermind is supposed to be an exceptional - and thus rare - talent within their field.

That said, as monteparnas noted, we love collecting data on crimes. The most common form of theft in the USA is wage-benefit theft. That is, when employers don't give their employees what they're supposed to for the labor provided. Minimum wage violations account for more theft than all interpersonal theft (robbery, carjacking, etc.) combined. By almost twice. But it seems like all of those criminals are pretty smart because they use corporate law and all of that stolen money to corrupt politicians and gut the regulators that would stop them from committing all this theft. And even if they do have to "get caught" because of some particularly egregious violations, the "company" did the crime, not the board, and the company can't be put in jail. So they pay a fine a fraction of how much they steal, and spend some more of PR campaigns to get the public over it.

All this aside... Curseborne is not a "no veil" setting. The supernatural is not integrated into society like superpowers are in superhero stories. Most normal people in Curseborne might be a bit more serious about superstitions and folk stories, but they're not yapping with ghosts and having magic done in trials to prove how a murderer can kill someone from a mile away. There isn't a supernatural conspiracy hiding the supernatural reality from people, but much like the CofD take on things, most people remain incredulous and avoidant of the supernatural because knowing is far more dangerous that ignoring.

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10-29-2026, 12:24 PM #13

Plus, I haven't read the whole book yet, but there doesn't seem to be any kind of masquerade as far as I can tell. It's likely still wise to stay somewhat hidden but I haven't found where it says if you don't stay hidden in just the right way you are likely to be executed.

Zwyt
Member

Join Date: Nov 2013
Posts: 7

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monteparnas
Member

Join Date: Apr 2015
Posts: 6710

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10-29-2026, 08:55 PM #14

> *Originally posted by **Zwyt***
> *Plus, I haven't read the whole book yet, but there doesn't seem to be any kind of masquerade as far as I can tell. It's likely still wise to stay somewhat hidden but I haven't found where it says if you don't stay hidden in just the right way you are likely to be executed.*

But CoD doesn't, either.

Vampires have a Tradition, but is unevenly enforced when at all. Most others not even that.

It's at best implied that staying hidden is good for health, but nothing terribly concrete. You can flaunt your powers as much as you want if you manage to not fuck things up in the process, which is hard, but feasible.

Enforced secrecy is a WoD thing specifically.

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